



not have] a postgraduate, MBA qualification. So, I think, it worked out well in my favour. My father probably said no as he thought I would never come back to India. Maybe, he thought, I would get married to someone there and stay on. In those days we were obedient to our fathers, and I couldn't say no to him. Today if I say no to my children, they will just rebel and do things their way. But those days were very different.

Q: Yet, when you went about setting up Marico from scratch, you sought out people with the very academic pedigree you lacked. All of them came from the best business schools, and had worked for the best companies. Why?

A: I was absolutely clear that if I were to run a top-

notch FMCG business, I had to hire the best quality talent—best in terms of qualifications, attitude and also overall performance. I think that belief developed in my formative years, of always investing in talent. It played a crucial role in the success of Marico. I always looked for individuals who were better than me because I was not a functional expert. I had to recruit the best-quality marketing professional... the best quality sales professional in the hope that they would bring their experience to the table and add value to the company. Many entrepreneurs think they know it all, and that is the biggest mistake they make. They do not try to recruit somebody who is better than themselves. Perhaps it is insecurity. But I had a different view: I always needed to recruit someone better than what I was in that particular functional area. And then I was able to empower that individual and delegate to them, without abdicating my responsibility.

Q: There's an interesting anecdote in your book where Uday Kotak says that there are two kinds of companies in India: the king and his subjects type—a family-run company where the boss thinks he knows everything; and the other being the value-driven company, where all decisions are taken keeping only the firm's interests in mind regardless of what the owner thinks. He puts Marico in the second category. But when you look at the ecosystem today, candidly, do you see more of the first category?

A: I would say if they are family managed in terms of leadership, they are more in the first category—the king and his subjects. The biggest problem I find amongst entrepreneurs in India is that they think the company belongs to them. If you're running a company that is a public limited company—you may be the majority shareholder, the promoter, or the founder—that doesn't entitle you to call yourself owner, especially when you have diluted your ownership to many other shareholders. It's not right to say that this is my company. I never say Marico is mine; okay I may have a majority holding and that's fine. But, it is not my company and I have to look at all the stakeholders, even the smallest of shareholders and have to always decide in the interest of the company and not in the interest of promoters. Unfortunately, many promoters think their interests come first, followed by the interests of the company, which is just not right.

Q: The turf for FMCG has changed a lot today. When you were bringing the company up, you were up against giants like Hindustan Unilever or P&G but today there are smaller,